

GENDER SENSITISATION FOR BUS DRIVERS AND CONDUCTORS



Imprint

Published by the

Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) GmbH

Registered offices

Bonn and Eschborn, Germany

Sustainable Urban Mobility– Air Quality, Climate Action and Accessibility (SUM-ACA)

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<https://www.giz.de/en/projects/sustainable-urban-mobility-air-quality-climate-protection-and-accessibility-sut-aca>

As at

June 2026

Commissioned by

Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development (BMZ), Germany

Political Partner

Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), Government of India

Implementation Partners

Rajkot Municipal Corporation (RMC)

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Photo Credits

GIZ; GFA; Manas Foundation

Citation

GIZ (2026). **Gender Sensitisation Training for bus drivers and conductors, Rajkot.** SUM-ACA. New Delhi, India.

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Executive Summary

Manas Foundation is a Delhi-based civil society organization specializing in mental health, with over two decades of experience implementing interventions across diverse regions of India. The organization initially focused on delivering direct mental health services to communities from varied socioeconomic backgrounds, adopting a psychosocial approach that combines psychiatric care with broader social support systems.

Building on its commitment to gender justice and mental well-being, Manas Foundation, in collaboration with Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ), launched a flagship initiative aimed at promoting safer and more equitable public transportation for women and girls. This program represents one of the largest efforts to engage male public transport drivers, with the objective of fostering behavioral change, improving professional conduct, and ensuring safer commuting environments. At the same time, the initiative addresses stress and coping challenges faced by drivers due to their vulnerable socioeconomic conditions.

As part of this initiative, Gender Sensitization Workshops were conducted in partnership with GIZ and Rajkot Rajpath Limited, targeting bus drivers and conductors. These workshops mark the beginning of a structured program designed to bring about transformative improvements in the working and service environment of public transport systems. The initiative aims to create an enabling and inclusive ecosystem that supports women's participation both as users and as members of the transport workforce.

Furthermore, the program seeks to enhance the visibility and acceptance of women in traditionally male-dominated roles within the transport sector, contributing to long-term social and institutional change.

Key Totals

Total training (sessions): 12

Total participants: 352

Depot / location	No. of sessions	Total participants
Aji Bus Depot	5	126
Atal Bus Depot	5	189
Rajkot Rajpath Limited Office	2	37
TOTAL	12	352

Note: Gender breakdown not consistently recorded.

1. OVERVIEW

The Gender Sensitization Workshops were designed to strengthen the understanding of gender sensitivity among public transport staff, particularly those interacting with passengers daily. The sessions aimed to build empathy, challenge stereotypes, and provide practical tools for preventing and addressing sexual harassment in buses and public spaces.

The content was grounded in local realities, drawing on the social, cultural, and economic context of Rajkot. Discussions highlighted the gendered nature of mobility, where women often rely more on public transport, plan travel carefully for safety, and face restrictions on traveling alone. Men, on the other hand, often enjoy greater freedom in mobility. This contrast was brought to life through participant stories and group reflections.

1.1 Workshops explored:

- Daily realities for male and female commuters- from route choices to time-of-day considerations.
- Prevalence of harassment in public transport and its deterrent effect on women's mobility.
- Legal frameworks and SOPs for prevention and response, including helplines and the importance of prompt action.
- Role of bus staff as first respondents- building trust, ensuring respectful communication, and maintaining a safe environment.
- Cyber safety concerns, given the growing incidence of online harassment.

Participants engaged in interactive discussions, analysed real incidents from Rajkot and Gujarat, and practiced correct responses through role-play. The emphasis throughout was on respectful, inclusive, and professional conduct that enables safe travel for all.

2. OBJECTIVES

1. Enhance Awareness and Challenge Biases: Increase understanding of gender differences in mobility and safety, address stereotypes and victim-blaming attitudes, and promote respect for all passengers, including marginalized groups.

2. Strengthen Legal and Procedural Knowledge: Equip bus staff with knowledge of laws, anti-harassment provisions, emergency helplines, and Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) to handle safety incidents, theft, harassment, and conflicts effectively.

3. Foster Safer, Inclusive Transport Environments: Create respectful, welcoming, and visibly safe spaces that encourage women's use of public buses, build public trust, and promote equitable treatment across all genders.

4. Build Professional Responsibility and Action-readiness: Reinforce the role of drivers and conductors as custodians of public safety, empowering them to intervene promptly, report incidents lawfully, and protect both passengers and themselves.

3. STRUCTURE & EXECUTION

The workshops followed a consistent framework across all depots, while making adjustments for group size, participant backgrounds, shift timings, and operational realities of the public transport system. Trainers balanced structured delivery with flexibility to address spontaneous questions and localized issues raised by participants.

3.1 Session Length:

- Standard duration was two hours, but in smaller groups or highly engaged sessions, discussions often extended to 2.5–3 hours.
- Timings were planned to avoid peak duty hours and minimize disruption to the transport schedule, often held in early mornings or late evenings.
- In some depots with staggered attendance (due to duty changes), trainers repeated core points for latecomers to ensure everyone received the same key information.

3.2 Facilitation Approach:

- Sessions were led by Manas Foundation trainers with extensive experience in gender sensitization and public-facing safety training.
- The approach was participatory and conversational rather than purely lecture-based, designed to make participants feel comfortable in expressing their views, even when those views reflected problematic mindsets.
- Trainers used storytelling, real examples from Rajkot, and humor were appropriated to sustain attention while ensuring the seriousness of the subject matter remained clear.

3.3 Opening Segment:

- Included brief introductions, often starting with participants stating their name, role, and number of years in service.
- Used icebreakers like quick scenario questions ("What would you do if a passenger

reported harassment to you right now?”) to prompt thinking and set the tone.

- Participants were encouraged to share personal or observed experiences from their work, both positive and negative, regarding passenger safety. This created an immediate link between the training content and their lived reality.

3.4 Core Content Delivery:



Figure 1 Trainer delivering core session content to participants.

- **Data Presentation:** Local and national statistics on crimes against women and harassment in public spaces were shared, making the case for why gender sensitivity in transport a public safety priority is. In some sessions, participants were surprised at the scale of reported incidents.
- **Gendered Mobility Patterns:** Trainers highlighted differences in how men and women plan travel, drawing examples from Rajkot (e.g., women avoiding late-night buses, choosing well-lit stops).
- **Legal Frameworks & Helplines:** Participants were walked through relevant transport laws, anti-harassment provisions, and the correct use of local helpline numbers. Trainers explained how timely reporting protects both passengers and staff.

3.5 Interactive Activities:

- **Role-Play Exercises:** Participants engaged in enactments of common situations such as harassment of a female passenger by a male co-traveler, incidents of pick-pocketing, and verbal altercations. Roles were rotated among victims, offender, and conductor/driver. Trainers intervened during the role-plays to reinforce Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) and guide appropriate responses.

- **Problem-Solving Group Work:** Small groups were tasked with examining complex cases, for example, an aggressive passenger unwilling to cooperate or a harassment complaint without witnesses. Each group proposed solutions which were later consolidated through a larger discussion to highlight safe and practical intervention strategies.
- **Case Study Reflection Sessions:** Participants shared real-life experiences from their routes. Trainers used these accounts to connect back to SOP requirements, legal responsibilities, and effective communication practices.

3.6 Language & Accessibility:

- All sessions were delivered in Hindi and Gujarati; trainers alternated between the two depending on the participant's comfort.
- Technical or legal terms were simplified, and visual aids (charts, posters, SOP flowcharts) were used to reinforce understanding.
- Trainers paid attention to non-verbal participation cues, especially for quieter members, ensuring they were drawn into the discussion.

3.7 Closing & Feedback:

- Trainers summarized 3–5 key takeaways, ensuring that all participants could articulate at least one change they would make in their daily practice.
- Feedback was both verbal and sometimes written (where literacy levels allowed), with participants noting what they found most useful and any remaining doubts.
- In several sessions, participants expressed intentions to share learnings with colleagues who had not attended.



Figure 2 Closing session with participants reflecting on key learnings.

3.8 Follow-up Guidance:

- Participants were advised to keep SOP copies or helpline numbers in their wallets or pasted inside the bus cabin for quick reference.
- Trainers encouraged them to report incidents promptly, even if minor, to build a culture of accountability.
- Where possible, depot supervisors were briefed to reinforce key messages in future staff meetings.

4. OBSERVATIONS

4.1 Participant Engagement and Response

Across most depots, participants showed a strong willingness to participate, especially when discussions were grounded in real incidents or operational challenges they had personally encountered. Role-play exercises consistently emerged as the most effective component, enabling participants to rehearse appropriate responses while observing the value of SOP adherence in real-world scenarios. In multiple sessions, drivers and conductors contributed personal accounts of addressing harassment, theft, or passenger disputes, which deepened the relevance of discussions and enhanced peer learning.

That said, engagement levels varied in larger groups. In some cases, a few dominant voices steered the conversation, requiring trainers to actively encourage quieter participants to share their perspectives and ensure balanced participation.

“I found the discussion on women's safety, gender equality, and discrimination particularly insightful. The training helped me understand why gender-based discrimination exists, when such mentalities are formed in society, and what role and responsibility each of us holds in changing that mindset. I also found it very useful to learn about the legal protections, especially IPC Sections 354 and 509, which are crucial for ensuring women's safety in public transport. What stood out to me was understanding the steps we, as conductors and drivers, can take when harassment incidents occur on buses, both to protect ourselves and to support passengers, especially women. I now realize how important it is to deal with passengers professionally and to create a safe and supportive environment in public transportation systems.” - Ms. Parmar Vanita

4.2. Attitudes and Perceptions

A recurring theme was the persistence of entrenched gender biases and victim-blaming attitudes. Some participants expressed views suggesting that women's dress or behaviour contributed to harassment, indicating the need for more targeted modules on dismantling myths and shifting mindsets. At the same time, others acknowledged that safety concerns were genuine and that their role as transport staff carried a responsibility to intervene and protect passengers.

An interesting observation emerged from Rajkot City: women there are generally seen to be bold and defensive, which appears to contribute to comparatively lower incidents of sexual harassment against adult women. However, reported cases of sexual harassment involving girls under 18 years of age are comparatively higher.

4.3. Language and Communication

Sessions were conducted in Hindi and Gujarati, which helped accessibility, but occasional language mismatches occurred, particularly where participants were more comfortable in one language than the other. In mixed groups, facilitators had to repeat key points in both languages to ensure clarity, which sometimes slowed the session pace.

4.4. Learning and Retention



Figure 3 Participants engaged in an interactive exercise during the training session.

Participants generally retained factual information, such as helpline numbers, the existence of specific laws, and the steps in SOPs, especially when presented visually or reinforced through practice. Role-play was key to embedding this knowledge. However, the short duration of sessions (often two hours) meant that some complex topics could not be explored in depth, risking superficial understanding.

4.5. Operational Realities

Many participants cited operational challenges to applying SOPs fully. These included tight bus schedules, passenger impatience, and the pressure to avoid delays. Some felt that while SOPs were ideal in principle, in practice they would need stronger institutional support to implement them without repercussions from supervisors or passengers.

“A real-life incident was shared where an individual entered the bus with a knife due to an old rivalry, creating panic among the passengers. The conductor and driver responded quickly, removed the person from the bus, and reported the situation to the office, this example was used to highlight the importance of quick decision-making and presence of mind.”- Participant, RRL office

4.6. Venue and Logistics



Figure 4 Depot-based sessions

Depot-based sessions generally provided a conducive environment for learning. Seating arrangements in some venues limited visibility of visual materials, reducing the effectiveness of presentations.

4.7. Attendance and Representation



Figure 5 Workshop session with a large group of participants, reflecting varying levels of gender representation.

Attendance numbers varied widely between sessions, although majority the participation crossed 30 to 80 per session. The majority of participants were male; very few female staff attended, limiting gender-diverse perspectives in discussions. This imbalance also highlights the need to actively encourage women's participation in future training rounds.

4.8. Positive Shifts and Recommendations

Where engagement was high, participants left with a noticeably stronger understanding of their responsibilities and expressed commitment to applying what they had learned. The workshops were particularly effective in fostering empathy when discussions connected directly to personal or local experiences. To build on this success, future training should consider:

- Longer or follow-up sessions for deeper discussion on bias and behaviour change.
- Stronger emphasis on case studies from within Rajkot to maintain relevance.
- Strategies to address operational barriers to SOP compliance.
- Active outreach to increase female participation.

Ashish (Driver's Feedback):

"Most of the points in the workshop were important, but I learned the most from the discussions on gender equality and gender-based violence. I now know how I can help if I notice such incidents happening in my vehicle. After the session, I also talked about these learnings with other drivers during lunchtime and with my family at home. I feel this kind of training really changes our thinking and mentality towards women, both in our families and in society."

5. KEY CHALLENGES/INSIGHTS

5.1. Victim-blaming attitudes

Participant challenge: Victim blaming was found to be a common theme here as well. They shared that the idea of women dressing up in a certain way during nighttime are contributing factor to the incidents of sexual harassment.

Trainer response: Facilitators addressed this firmly, explaining that harassment is the offender's action, not the victims. They used real-world statistics and scenarios to show harassment occurs across all dress styles, times of day, and age groups. Role-plays illustrated how victim-blaming undermines safety and discourages reporting.

5.2. Operational constraints in applying SOPs

Participant challenge: drivers shared that many a time they face this particular situation where another vehicle is deliberately parked in front of their buses, and they have tried everything whether to reach out to police or talk calmly with the person, but nothing worked.

Trainer response: Trainers acknowledged the operational difficulty in such situation and suggested that the drivers take the matter with the operational head and file a written complaint there for assistance. They also suggested following up actively on the matter.

5.3. Handling harassment discreetly

Participant challenge: Drivers and conductors shared their concern on how they can be discreet about incidents when there a lot of people witnessing it. One such incident was shared too, where a person entered the bus with a knife creating panic, though they intervened smartly but situations like this can't be discreet.

Trainer response: Trainers highlighted the difference between sexual harassment and such incidents and acknowledged that situations like this might occur in front of public but still the victim's safe space needs to be prioritized. Trainers guided them on discreet yet effective intervention, positioning themselves nearby, creating a physical barrier, speaking calmly, and moving the victim to a safer seat while signaling for assistance. They emphasized that protecting the victim's dignity is as important as stopping the incident.

5.4. Gender diversity in public transport staff

Participant insight: A few participants suggested that more women in transport roles (drivers, conductors) might make female passengers feel safer.

Trainer response: Trainers validated this insight, linking it to studies showing improved perception of safety when women are represented in service roles. They encouraged participants to support such hiring policies and create respectful workplaces to retain women employees



Figure 6 Participants taking a pledge towards promoting gender equality and inclusivity in public transport.

5.6. Dealing with false complaints

Participant challenge: Some feared that passengers might file false harassment complaints.

Trainer response: Trainers clarified that while rare, false complaints can occur, but the best safeguard is professional, rule-based conduct always.

SOPs not only protect passengers but also protect staff from wrongful allegations by ensuring actions are transparent and documented.

5.7. Understanding harassment beyond physical contact

Participant challenge: Some participants believed harassment was only physical.

Trainer response: Trainers expanded the definition to include verbal abuse, lewd gestures, staring, and cyber harassment, explaining the psychological impact of these behaviors and reinforcing that they are equally unacceptable under the law.



Figure 7 Participants engaged in a training session discussing





